Not officially present in Fiji, the R&AW could do nothing but watch events unfold and send reports to the Indian government. 'So, what did the spies do?' I asked Shekhawat.

'About a week before the coup on 14 May, a report had forewarned the Indian government about the conspiracy being hatched by Sitiveni Rabuka who planned to justify the coup by arguing [that] it was done to restore law and order in the country,' Shekhawat told me. 'This was indeed true. Rabuka later contended that the coup was a matter of cultural survival for ethnic Fijians as Indians had become dominant in his country. He wanted the Indians practising Hinduism and Islam to convert to Christianity. And he wanted them deported. He wanted all the Indians out of the Fiji Islands. Bavadra pleaded with opposition leaders to give his government a chance to govern. But on 14 May 1987, Rabuka and ten soldiers entered parliament and announced a military takeover. The entire cabinet was bundled together in a military truck headed for the Royal Fiji Military office where they were held at gunpoint. They were released later, but kept under intense surveillance.'

When Rajiv Gandhi met the R&AW chief a week later, the discussion meandered between diplomatic pressure and covert action to help the Indians in Fiji. Gandhi was assured by a top spy that while they had not been able to stop the coup that day, the tradecraft they had earned in the last eighteen years gave them tremendous capability to effectively counter any political and terror threats. Over the next few days, Gandhi spoke to his counterparts in Australia, New Zealand and the UK for the restoration of the Bavadra government. A CIA report said Rajiv Gandhi had also sent two special envoys to Canberra, Wellington and London for the same purpose and the Indian